"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, cooler, partly cloudy, high 59. **Tonight,** cool in the evening, partly cloudy, low 47. **Tomorrow,** more sun than clouds, dry for the marathon, high 61. Weather map, Page B10.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,054 © 2026 The New York Times Company SATURDAY, OCTOBER 31, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00

Binance Heist Sends Alarms About Crypto

$6.3 Billion Hack Puts Flaws in Vivid View

By DAVID YAFFE-BELLANY and DUSTIN VOLZ

In February 2025, a team of North Korean hackers stole $1.5 billion from the cryptocurrency exchange Bybit — a dark day for the industry and the largest crypto heist ever recorded.

Now that number looks paltry.

Binance, the world's biggest crypto exchange, set an unwanted record on Thursday, losing $6.3 billion to hackers in an eye-popping attack that highlighted the deep vulnerabilities in crypto's financial infrastructure.

For years, the industry has struggled to prevent thefts. Now, the risks are growing even more extreme as attackers use artificial intelligence and other advanced techniques to steal funds and quickly launder them, crypto analysts and security experts said.

The Binance attacker used "laundering patterns we have not seen before," the crypto analytics firm Chainalysis wrote in a blog post on Friday. "Thousands of transactions in a short period suggest that the attackers are using automation to obscure the trail of funds."

The details of how Binance was breached are still coming into focus. Both Chainalysis and TRM Labs, another analytics firm, attributed the hack to North Korea, which has targeted crypto companies for years. Binance initially said the attacker appeared to have compromised a laptop belonging to one of its engineers, before clarifying that further investigation had uncovered "additional points of breach."

Binance has promised to make customers whole and said it had set aside more than $6.3 billion in company funds to cover the losses. (Binance processes billions of dollars in transactions every day.) Of the total that was stolen, $3 billion has been frozen by other companies, including Circle and Tether, two large issuers of digital coins that have the ability to stop the movement of stolen funds.

That means North Korea won't have access to those coins, and Binance said it was working on recovering them. But the hackers

Continued on Page A10

A 'smart wall' of towers with A.I.-aided cameras is a growing tool against illegal immigration. But it comes at a cost to privacy.



PAUL RATJE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump has secured $1 billion for towers such as this one near Sunland Park, N.M.

Watching Border, and Those Who Live Near

By BORA ERDEN and NICHOLAS NEHAMAS

For decades, Republicans and Democrats agreed that a "smart wall" of surveillance cameras and other high-tech equipment would be a potent tool to stop illegal immigration and drug trafficking across the southern border.

Now, the smart wall has arrived — and it is more powerful than many could have imagined.

Already, more than one million people in the United States and Mexico live in areas along the border where they can be seen by A.I.-powered surveillance towers, a New York Times analysis found. At least four million more live within view of an older generation of cameras that the government plans to retrofit with A.I. technology.

And the Trump administration has secured more than $1 billion to build 1,500 new A.I. towers. The goal is full coverage along the U.S. border with Mexico, and there are plans to install towers near Canada, as well as in coastal areas and in Puerto Rico.

But a rising public backlash against A.I. and growing anxiety over mass surveillance have left some communities with an uncomfortable question: Is the potential loss of privacy worth it?

To understand the new technology, Times reporters visited two dozen A.I. towers in California, Arizona, New Mexico and Texas and used a drone equipped with a camera to recreate what

Continued on Page A11

Health Care Divides Focus: Fraud vs. Cost

Divergent Strategies in Final Midterms Push

By SHERYL GAY STOLBERG

LA CROSSE, Wis. — When Representative Derrick Van Orden, an endangered Republican congressman in western Wisconsin, appeared recently with hospital executives, he said his goal was to root out fraud in Medicaid so that "every dollar that's allocated" would "go to someone that needs medical care, or a hungry child."

Rebecca Cooke, his Democratic challenger, has an entirely different health care message. Last week, she stood in front of a giant blue bus emblazoned with "Sick of It! Fix Health Care Now." in a park overlooking a river marsh.

"I've talked to people here in the city of La Crosse, small-business owners who have seen their premiums go up from $400 to $1,800 a month," Ms. Cooke said then, at an event hosted by "Protect Our Care," a left-leaning nonprofit. "People are really, really hanging on by a thread here."

The dueling messages in a crucial state encapsulate the different approaches to an issue high on voters' minds in the final days of the campaign. As the 2026 midterm season barrels toward a close, the two parties are talking past each other on health care. Republicans see the big problem as fraud. Democrats say it is cost.

Polls show clear partisan differences in what voters think. A recent survey by KFF, a health policy research organization, found that Democrats were twice as likely as Republicans to say addressing health care costs was "extremely important."

After spending much of 2026 citing the high price of gas and groceries as proof of an "affordability crisis," it makes sense for Democrats to build their closing argument around health costs, said Celinda Lake, a Democratic strategist.

"A lot of races are finishing on it," she said. "It's the No. 1 cost-of-living issue where Democrats have the biggest advantage."

Fraud in government programs is Republicans' top issue, the KFF survey found, with more than half calling it "extremely important." Mollyann Brodie, who oversees polling and research at KFF, said Republicans may be building messages around fraud to close the "enthusiasm gap" in what looks, for them, to be a tough year.

Continued on Page A19

STICKER SHOCK Millions on Obamacare plans will face another large price increase. PAGE B3

CRIPPLING PRICES ARE TRIPPING UP TRUMP AND G.O.P.

BRIGHT SPOTS ECLIPSED

Similar Economic Factors Doomed Democrats in 2024 Election

By TONY ROMM

WASHINGTON — On the final Tuesday before the midterm election, President Trump found himself in Corpus Christi, Texas, musing aloud about the political forces that had propelled his return to office two years earlier.

"I got elected because of high prices," he told rallygoers in a state that has become the site of an unexpectedly close Senate race. Then the president turned his ire toward Democrats: "I didn't have the high prices. They had the high prices."

For Mr. Trump, that previous source of political strength now threatens to topple Republicans in 2026. The fate of the party's control of Congress may well hinge on the depth of voters' fury with the rising cost of living — and the president's unmet promises to do something about it.

The concern among Republicans has been evident as Mr. Trump crisscrosses the country in an 11th-hour campaign sprint. He has tried to present the economy as strong, growing and rife with new investment, while downplaying the fact that inflation has clearly worsened under his party's stewardship.

Offering a final snapshot on the state of the economy before Election Day, a set of government reports on Thursday confirmed some of Mr. Trump's claims and undercut others. The data showed that the economy was indeed expanding at a faster clip, with a key measure of its total output increasing at a 3.4 percent annual rate this summer. But prices also accelerated, rising more rapidly in September compared with a year earlier, and continuing to outpace wage gains.

As a result, Mr. Trump's message contrasted with the experience of voters, who see the harsh realities of a high-cost economy every day — when they fill up their gas tanks, shop for groceries, pay their health insurance premiums, receive their credit card bills and confront the difficulties of homeownership.

Having weathered almost two years of high tariffs, geopolitical discord and other economic shocks, voters seem inclined to exact another round of political vengeance at the ballot box, or so

Continued on Page A14

PATRICK STEWART, 1940-2026

Shakespearean Actor Turned Starship Captain

By ANITA GATES and WILLIAM McDONALD

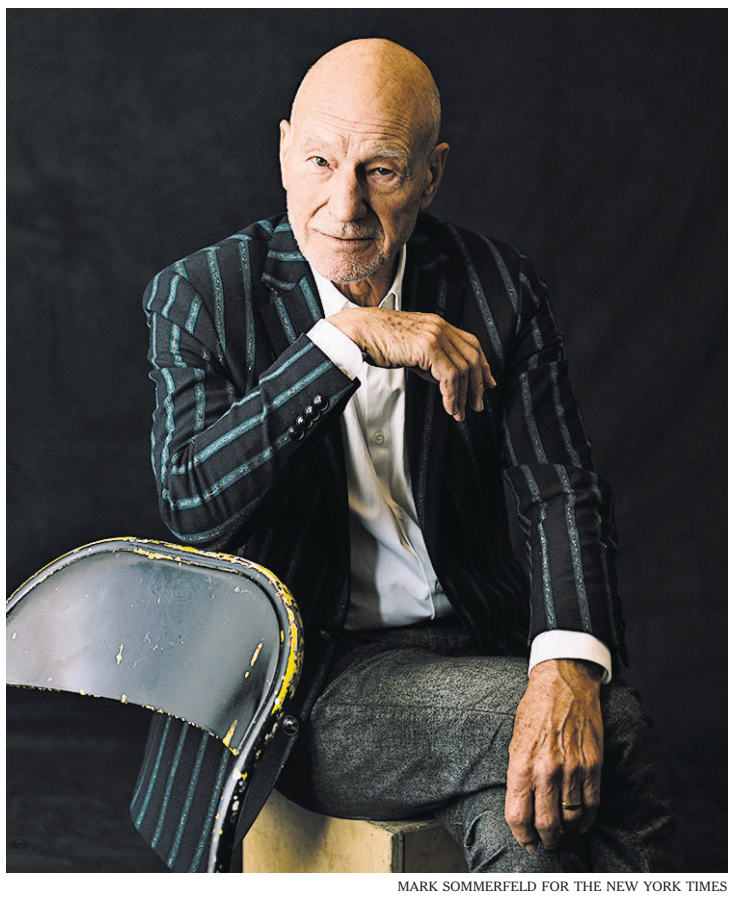
Patrick Stewart, who overcame a bleak childhood in England's coal-mining country to find acclaim as a Shakespearean actor before making an unlikely career pivot in middle age that would bring him his greatest fame, playing a noble starship captain on the TV series "Star Trek: The Next Generation," died on Wednesday at his home in Los Angeles. He was 86.

The death, from Alzheimer's disease and Lewy body dementia, was announced on social media.

With a commanding baritone voice — he had shed his Yorkshire dialect as an acting student — Mr. Stewart was by his late 40s an eloquent, statesmanlike presence on the British stage. But to many American television viewers, Mr. Stewart was a new face when he made his debut in 1987 as Capt. Jean-Luc Picard in "The Next Generation," the first live-action spinoff of the original "Star Trek" series of the late 1960s.

Old and new fans embraced the balding, graying Picard and the members of his 24th-century

Continued on Page A20



MARK SOMMERFELD FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Patrick Stewart at Comic Con in New York City in 2019.

Pacing Treats Or Gorging: Is One Better?

By ALICE CALLAHAN

Whether it comes from your kid's trick-or-treat haul, an office break room or the drugstore, 'tis the season for excess candy.

There's nothing wrong with indulging in the seasonal sweets. But when it comes to the health consequences of consuming extra calories and sugar, is it best to pace yourself, eating a few pieces each day for weeks — or should you gorge for a day or two until it's gone?

Unsurprisingly, scientists haven't studied this question directly, said Nicola Guess, a dietitian and metabolic health researcher at the University of Oxford, so "it's a real conundrum." But based on what we know about how our bodies handle sugar, there can be pros and cons to each approach.

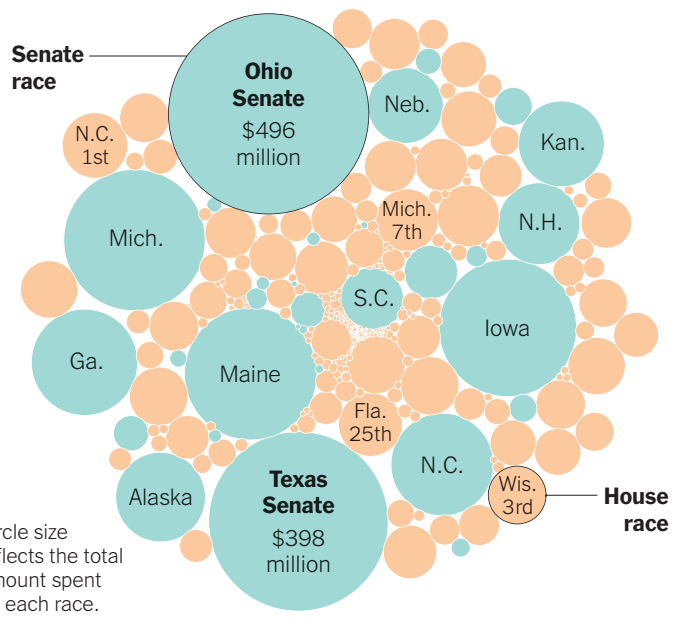
Let's say you limit yourself to an ounce of candy — or about two to three "fun-sized" or "mini" pieces — per day, Dr. Guess said.

That amount might contain about 12 to 23 grams of added sugars. Assuming you're not eating

Continued on Page A18

Parties Spend Billions on Campaign Ads

Most of the money will be spent on advertising in the closest House and Senate races, according to a New York Times analysis. Page A14.



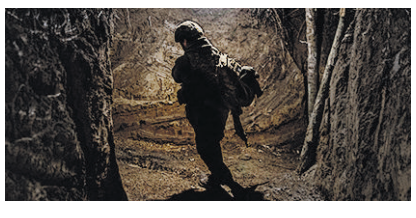
$3.9 billion total for 428 races

Note: Data is as of Oct. 27. Source: AdImpact. JILLIAN VORDICK/THE NEW YORK TIMES

INTERNATIONAL A4-8

Targeting a West Bank Rite
Israeli settlers have attacked Palestinian farmers and besieged homes during this year's olive harvest. PAGE A7

Ukraine's Underground War
A Times reporter spent time with soldiers fighting from old gas pipes in an attempt to evade drones. PAGE A8



NATIONAL A9-19

Change for Would-Be Justices
Supreme Court aspirants usually avoid talking about how they might rule. The president's discontent with his first-term picks may be changing that. PAGE A10

More Charges for Comey
Prosecutors defended an unusual case accusing James Comey of leaking classified information a decade ago. PAGE A19

BUSINESS B1-5

Paying to Make New Friends
Apps that match personalities — for a price — have surged in popularity amid a loneliness epidemic. PAGE B1

SPORTS B6-9

How Forecasts Can Foretell
For thousands of runners in the New York City Marathon, the weather could make or break their hopes. PAGE B9

In W.N.B.A., Settling It All
Can Angel Reese, right, carry the Atlanta Dream past the Golden State Valkyries in Game 7 of the finals? PAGE B6



ARTS C1-6

Defining 'Weird Girl Lit'
An online community "for lovers of feminine interiority turned feral, obsessive, humiliating, erotic, and unhinged" celebrates novels whose authors sometimes resist the categorization. PAGE C1

An Anchor of the Jazz Scene
The exacting multi-instrumentalist Josh Johnson, a trusted producer for musicians like Meshell Ndegeocello and Flea, goes in a new direction with his latest album, "Animative." PAGE C1

OPINION A22-23

Jamelle Bouie PAGE A22

MAGAZINE



THIS WEEKEND